

Samudra manthan (*churning of the ocean*) is one of the best known episodes in Hindu mythology. The story appears in the Bhagavata Purana, the Mahabharata and the Vishnu Purana, and explains the origin of amrita, the drink of immortality.

Legend

1. Indra, the King of Devas (gods), while riding on the elephant Airavata, came across Sage Durvasa who offered him a special garland given to him by the God Shiva. Indra accepted the garland and placed it on the trunk of the elephant as a test to prove that he was not an egoistic god. The elephant, knowing that Indra had no control over his own ego, threw the garland to the ground. This enraged the sage as the garland was a dwelling of *Sri* (fortune) and was to be treated as a *prasada* or religious offering. Durvasa cursed Indra and all devas to be bereft of all strength, energy, and fortune.
2. In battles following the incident, the Devas were defeated and Asuras (demons) led by King Bali, gained control of the universe. Devas sought help from the Supreme God Vishnu who advised them to treat asuras in a diplomatic manner. Devas formed an alliance with asuras to jointly churn the ocean for the nectar of immortality and to share it among them. However, Vishnu told the Devas that he would arrange that they alone obtain the nectar.
3. The churning of the Ocean of Milk was an elaborate process. Mount Mandara was used as the churning rod, and Vasuki, the king of serpents, who abides on Shiva's neck, became the churning rope. The demons demanded to hold the head of the snake, while the gods, taking advice from Vishnu, agreed to hold its tail. As a result, the demons were poisoned by fumes emitted by Vasuki. Despite this, the gods and demons pulled back and forth on the snake's body alternately, causing the mountain to rotate, which in turn churned the ocean. When the mountain was placed on the ocean, it began to sink. Vishnu, in the form of a turtle Kurma, came to their rescue and supported the mountain on his back.
4. The Samudra Manthan process released a number of things from the Ocean of Milk. One was the lethal poison known as *Halahala*, which in some versions of the story, escaped from the mouth of the serpent king as the demons and gods churned. This terrified the gods and demons because the poison was so powerful that it could destroy all of creation. Then the gods approached Shiva for protection. Shiva consumed the poison in an act to protect the universe, and his wife Parvati grabbed Shiva's throat in an effort to prevent him from swallowing the poison, which was the most deadly poison in existence, harmful even to a god. As a result, Shiva's throat turned blue. For this reason, Lord Shiva is also called *Neelakantha* (the blue-throated one; "neela" = "blue", "kantha" = "throat" in Sanskrit).

Ratnas



All kinds of herbs were cast into the ocean and fourteen Ratnas (gems or treasures) were produced from the ocean and were divided between asuras and gods. Though usually the Ratnas are enumerated as 14, the list in the scriptures ranges from 9 to 14 Ratnas. Most lists include:

Lakshmi = the Goddess of Fortune and Wealth - who accepted Vishnu as Her eternal consort.

Likewise = 3 types of supernatural animals appeared;

- Kamadhenu or Surabhi = the wish-granting divine cow - taken by Vishnu, and given to sages so ghee from her milk could be used for Yajna and similar rituals.
- Airavata, and several other elephants, taken by Indra, leader of the Deva.
- Uchhaishravas = the divine 7-headed horse - given to the Indra.

There were three valuables;

- Kaustubha = the most valuable Ratna in the world, a jewel that represents pure consciousness shining in all its luminous manifestations, worn by Lord Vishnu.
- Parijat = the divine flowering tree with blossoms that never fade or wilt - taken to Indraloka by the Devas.
- Sharanga = A powerful bow - symbolic of the demon's belligerence.

Additionally produced were;

- Chandra = the moon which adorned Shiva's head
- Dhanvantari, an avatar of Vishnu who appears in the *Vedas* and *Puranas* as the physician of the gods (devas)
- Halahala = the poison swallowed by the lord Shiva.

This list varies from Purana to Purana and is also slightly different in the epics, the Ramayana and Mahabharata.

The nectar of immortality



Finally, Dhanvantari, the heavenly physician, emerged with a pot containing *Amrita*, the heavenly nectar of immortality. Fierce fighting ensued between Devas and Asuras for the nectar. To protect the nectar from Asuras, the divine Garuda took the pot, and flew away from the battle-scene.

The Devas appealed to Vishnu, who then took the form of Mohini and as a beautiful and enchanting damsel, Mohini distracted the asuras, took the amrita, and distributed it among the Devas, who drank it. Asura RahuKetu, disguised himself as a deva and drank some nectar. Due to their luminous nature, the sun god Surya and the moon god Chandra noticed the switching of sides. They informed Mohini. But before the nectar could pass his throat, Mohini cut off his head with her divine discus, the Sudarshana Chakra. But as the nectar had gone down his throat he did not die. From that day, his head was called Rahu and body was called Ketu. Later Rahu and Ketu became planets. The story ends with the rejuvenated Devas defeating the asuras.

<https://www.templepurohit.com/the-churning-of-the-ocean-of-milk/>

The symbolism

The story represents the spiritual endeavor of man for gaining immortality through concentration of mind, withdrawal of senses, control of desires and practice of austerities and asceticism. The gods represent the pleasure principle in ourselves. The demons represent the pain principle. The gods also represent the senses, while the demons the evil and negative thoughts and impulses. The participation of both the devas and the demons signify the fact that when one is seeking immortality through the spiritual practice one has to integrate and harmonize both the positive and negative aspects of one's personality and put both the energies for the common goal.

The ocean of milk is the mind or the human consciousness. The mind is always compared to an ocean (mano sagaram) while the thoughts and emotions to the waves. The mind as an ocean is in fact a universal symbol, known to other religions and cultures also.

Mandhara, the mountain stands for concentration. The word "Mandhara" contains two words "man" (mind) and "dhara" (a single line) which means holding the mind in one line. This is possible only during mental concentration.

The mountain Mandhara was upheld by Lord Vishnu as a Tortoise (Kurma). The tortoise here stands for the withdrawal of the senses into one self as one practices mental concentration and meditation or contemplation. It also suggests that the mind should rest itself upon or freely surrender itself to the divine will.

The great serpent Vasuki stands for desire. The desire is always compared to a thousand hooded serpent. The Vasuki used in the churning of the ocean denotes that the deva's and the demons held desire (to seek immortality) as a rope and churned the mind with the help of concentration and withdrawal of the senses. You can hold desire in your hands and manipulate

it only when you have control over your desires. So control of desire is suggested through this symbolism.

The Halahala represents suffering and pain we undergo at the beginning of spiritual sadhana. When the mind is subjected to intense churning by opposing forces, the first thing that comes out of the process is intense suffering and great inner turmoil. We are told by many that when an initiate starts his spiritual sadhana he faces a number of difficulties. The problems become intensified because of inner conflicts, where one part yearns to pursue the spiritual path while the other opposes it. In the initial stages of sadhana a seeker's mind throws out all kinds of reactions, negative thoughts, desires and impulses out into open so that he can deal with them appropriately. These problems are basically physical suffering and mental suffering without resolving which further progress is not possible. In short we can say that Halahala is the instability of the body and the mind that arise as a counter reaction against one's spiritual practice.

Lord Shiva represents the ascetic principle. He is the destroyer of illusion, one who is inertly detached, pure and austere. His role in this story as the consumer of poison suggests that one can deal with the early problems of spiritual life, such as the instability of the mind and its restlessness, by cultivating the qualities of Lord Shiva, namely, courage, initiative, willingness, discipline, simplicity, austerity, detachment, compassion, pure love and asceticism. Alternatively it also means gaining control over the mind through breath control. Lord Shiva is controller of breath. He is pranathan, or praneshwar, Lord of the Breath.

Lord Vishnu in the form of Mohini stands for delusion of the mind in the form of pride. It is the pride of achievement to which the asuras or the demons succumbed and thus lost their right to enter into the world of immortality. Pride and egoism are the last hurdles one has to overcome in spiritual life before experiencing self-realization.

